Culture, Theory and Critique

ISSN: 1473-5784 (Print) 1473-5776 (Online) Journal homepage: www.tandfonline.com/journals/rctc20

Women in the closet in Peyami Safa: homonationalism as an analytical category to read early republican Turkish literature

Seval Şahin

To cite this article: Seval Şahin (08 May 2025): Women in the closet in Peyami Safa: homonationalism as an analytical category to read early republican Turkish literature, Culture, Theory and Critique, DOI: 10.1080/14735784.2025.2475766

To link to this article: https://doi.org/10.1080/14735784.2025.2475766

Published online: 08 May 2025.

Submit your article to this journal

Article views: 223

View related articles

View Crossmark data

Full Terms & Conditions of access and use can be found at
https://www.tandfonline.com/action/journalInformation?journalCode=rctc20

CULTURE, THEORY AND CRITIQUE
https://doi.org/10.1080/14735784.2025.2475766

Routledge
Taylor & Francis Group

Check for updates

Women in the closet in Peyami Safa: homonationalism as an analytical category to read early republican Turkish literature

Seval Şahin

Turkish Language and Literature, Mimar Sinan Fine Arts University, İstanbul, Turkey

ABSTRACT
The novel *Havva'nın Üvey Kızları* [*The Stepdaughters of Eve*] (1928), written by Peyami Safa under the pseudonym Servet Bedi, was serialised during Turkey's early Republican period. The novel narrates the complex relationship between four lesbian women and the husband of one of these women. Through the husband's ostensibly tolerant attitude toward his wife and her female companions, the text suggests, according to the author, that the women ultimately come to view their homosexuality as a pathology, subsequently adopting more traditionally feminine roles. This article explores the husband's tolerance in the novel in relation to Jasbir K. Puar's concept of homonationalism. Finally, it employs Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick's paranoid reading as a technique to close-read queer texts.

KEYWORDS
Queer; homonationalism; Turkish literature; Peyami Safa; paranoid reading

Introduction

Peyami Safa is a canonical author in Turkish literature, renowned for his alignment with Turkish nationalism and his influential works since the establishment of the Republic. His works often conceptualise modernisation through a dualistic framework, contrasting the 'East' – representing traditional Muslim society and values – with the 'West', symbolising progressive, Westernised lifestyles. Within this dichotomy, Safa portrays women who deviate from traditional roles such as motherhood and family-building to pursue their own desires as peculiar and dangerous. Conversely, he depicts men as actors responsible for restraining and disciplining these women (Berktay 1999; Gürbilek 2012; Moran 2004). In contrast to the novels published under his real name, Safa, under his *nom de plume*, adopts a distinct approach to exploring modernity. In writings as Bedi, he employs different narrative techniques that focus on the dynamics between men and women, including relationships between mothers and sons, as well as fathers and sons (Ayda 1998; Şahin 2011; Üyepazarcı 2018).

After the proclamation of the Republic in Turkey, women played a significant role in the modernisation efforts aimed at erasing the 'remnants' of the Ottoman Empire. The Republic endeavoured to transform women into symbols of modernity by enacting dress code laws, encouraging women to abandon the veil and participate visibly in public life alongside men, granting them the right to vote and be elected, and prioritising

CONTACT Seval Şahin sevals@gmail.com
© 2025 Informa UK Limited, trading as Taylor & Francis Group

their education, particularly because they were seen as future mothers responsible for raising the next generation. However, these advancements were bounded by limitations imposed by men: women were expected not to indulge excessively in adornment, to uphold the sanctity and unity of the family, and to remain dedicated to their maternal duties of raising the nation's future children (Sancar 2004; Zihnioğlu 2003). Consequently, male intellectuals of the period frequently expressed their views on the attributes of modern Republican women. In 'Cumhuriyetin Kızı', ['The Republic's Girl'] Peyami Safa outlines these attributes as follows:

1. A woman who is independent, aggressive, feminist/socialist, and neither Turkish nor Muslim, like a man.
2. A degenerate, bourgeois woman obsessed with beauty.
3. A talkative, gossiping, tedious, and unimaginative housewife.
4. The true Turkish woman: Her headquarters is her home … She is vastly different from an enlightened Turkish woman, being a mother who performs her parenting and domestic duties with love, knowledge, and technical skill, while also possessing some awareness of global affairs (qtd in Sancar 2004, 119).

As evidenced in the above list, Safa consistently categorised women as either genuine or not throughout his literary works and newspaper articles, labelling and defining them accordingly. He emphasised the gender distinction between men and women, highlighting differences in biology and intelligence. Safa associated women with spirituality and sensuality, while men were linked to reason and intellect (2022). However, his novel *Havva'nın Üvey Kızları* extends this dualism beyond mere gender identities, exploring it through the lens of homo-hetero distinctions as well as the male-female divide.

Havva'nın Üvey Kızları, written under the pseudonym Server Bedi, was serialised in the *Son Saat* newspaper in 1928 and has yet to be published as a book (Soydan 2019). The work addresses female homosexuality, a topic Safa does not necessarily revisit in his later works. In the novel, Rıfkı, who marries one of the lesbian characters, approaches his wife's homosexuality and her relationship with other women with a semblance of tolerance. Through Rıfkı's perspective, the women are first met with tolerance and then redefined in masculine terms, finally reshaping the notion of 'woman'. This portrayal of gender identity, mediated by male tolerance, underscores the need for new analytical tools to discuss early Republican nationalism's strategies for shaping and regulating male and female bodies. Therefore, I propose employing Jasbir Puar's concept of homonationalism to understand Safa's queer novel within a Muslim societal context, in conjunction with Sedgwick's (1990) 'closet' metaphor and the method of paranoid reading.

Step-hood and sexuality

In this article, I analyse the tolerance displayed by the main male character in *Havva'nın Üvey Kızları* toward four lesbian women, adopting the lens of Puar's concept of homonationalism, as introduced in *Terrorist Assemblages* (2007) as a framework for understanding the construction of modernity. I interpret this tolerance as an example of homonationalism, through which the novel reflects Republican-era attitude towards

gender roles, particularly emphasising the preservation of the heterosexual family structure. While the father is portrayed as the order-establishing figure, the mother upholds the father's authority and nurtures the children, sacrificing for the family and the nation. This depiction reinforces heteronormativity and underscores the role of gender in the construction of the nation-state.

Puar first introduced the concept of homonationalism in *Terrorist Assemblages* (2007). Over time, this concept has evolved and been expanded by various scholars (e.g., Winer and Bolzendahl 2021). Homonationalism identifies a post-9/11 phenomenon in which LGBTQ+ movements in the United States gained acceptance to the extent that they aligned with the values of heterosexual, white American life. Puar argues that this support was presented as part of a uniquely American sexual nationalism and sexual exceptionalism, but it actually served to fuel Islamophobia. As previously marginalised LGBTQ+ individuals became more integrated into the national body, their non-normative sexual identities were redefined within the boundaries of national belonging. By endorsing non-heterosexual bodies that aligned with heteronormative American ideals, the state combined its Islamophobic rhetoric – employed to marginalise Muslims post-9/11 – with the discourse on LGBTQ+ individuals. This realignment restructured the acceptable and unacceptable elements within the nation. According to Puar, an internal threat (non-heterosexual identities) is assimilated into the national fabric to combat an external threat (Islam), provided these identities adhere closely to heteronormative standards. LGBTQ+ bodies that align with the 'white' nation are thus affirmed, and this affirmation is celebrated as a sign of modernity. Meanwhile, Muslims are portrayed as misogynistic and homophobic, in contrast to North America and Western Europe (Puar 2007, 8). Puar conceptualises these practices, which incorporate homosexuals into the nation and subsequently identify them as the nation's enemies, as homonationalism. Furthermore, Puar interrogates the other conditions and motivations that give rise to homonationalism:

> Like modernity, homonationalism can be resisted and re-signified, but not opted out of. […] In this sense, homonationalism is an analytic category deployed to understand and historicize how and why a nation's status as 'gay-friendly' has become desirable in the first place. Like modernity, homonationalism can be resisted and re-signified, but not opted out of: we are all conditioned by it and through it. (2013, 336)

As a discourse that constructs a narrative of LGBTQ+ inclusivity, homonationalism, as Puar states, should not be thought of as an identity, an accusation, or a flawed policy, but rather as an analytical framework for understanding state formation and the structure of modernity (2013, 336–339). Consequently, in both Puar's work and the scholarship that bulds on it, homonationalism is typically employed to analyse practices of ostensibly accepting or tolerating homosexuality, along with the underlying reasons for these practices, across different times and spaces in relation to modernity. A key underlying reason for such practices is the nation's effort to construct its own boundaries and define its citizens. This framework reveals how the acceptability of homosexuality is negotiated beyond the simple homosexual-heterosexual binary.

In the initial parts of *Havva'nın Üvey Kızları*, the male protagonist Rıfkı recognises and responds to homosexual bodies with tolerance. However, this is then followed by an effort to determine which individuals can be assimilated into the national body.

This approach is specifically related to the idea behind the 'modern woman', and more broadly, to the notion of the modern state. Rıfkı begins by accepting the homosexuality of the four women upon discovering it. Subsequently, he rehabilitates those among them who do not wish to live an alternative lifestyle and want to 'return to their femininity', thereby incorporating them into the ranks of acceptable citizens. Rıfkı achieves this integration by positioning the women as 'others' in relation to one another. After his discovery of their homosexuality, Rıfkı engages in conversations with them about womanhood, family, and motherhood. This causes them to question their relationships, which they had initially perceived as a form of sisterhood and romantic partnership. Consequently, they come to understand that, within the early Republican framework of female modernity, to be truly modern is to be a 'complete woman' – to form a family and embrace motherhood. They recognise that deviating from this path has led to their perceived degradation. Ultimately, two of the four women, though they do not become mothers, believe they must 'embrace their womanhood'. Of the remaining two, one becomes a mother, while the other renounces her 'unnatural' desires only on her deathbed – a realisation that comes too late, as she dies at the novel's conclusion.

Close-reading a literary work from 1928 that approaches female homosexuality with tolerance in a Muslim society, particularly through the perspective of its male protagonist, homonationalism offers a novel way to analyse the relationships between men and women and among women in the newly established Republic. This approach, following Puar's notion, allows us to examine the criteria for the acceptability of homosexual bodies and interpret the tolerance shown to homosexual women by the male figure representing the nation as an instance of homonationalism. Such tolerance is predicated on distinguishing between acceptable and unacceptable homosexual bodies, akin to the distinction Puar theorises. I argue that this tolerance implicitly delivers a political message by delineating the sexuality of the Republic's modern women and defining the boundaries of acceptable womanhood in the nation. Furthermore, the use of the term 'step' at the very beginning of the novel, which suggests distinctions between authenticity and inauthenticity, also aligns with this concept.

In *Havva'nın Üvey Kızları*, the term 'step' in the title immediately signals a sense of estrangement or incompleteness, a concept frequently used by the novel's main male character, Rıfkı, as he grapples with understanding the relationships among the four women. In Turkish, the adjective 'step' refers to someone who, though not biologically related, is treated as family. However it also implies that this person can never truly replace the 'real' or 'genuine' offspring. Thus, the notion of step-hood points to a dubious or ambiguous area. The title *Havva'nın Üvey Kızları* reinforces this ambiguity by referencing Eve from the holy scriptures, suggesting an entry into a strange domain outside of traditional religious acceptance. The three words in the title together signal an encounter with the unconventional, both individually and collectively. Here, I will employ the term 'peculiarity' to denote queerness and use the term 'queer' to underscore an exploration of queerness in a way that extends beyond sexuality, encompassing broader issues related to identity and belonging (Haralson 2009, 24).

In the context of Ottoman-Turkish literature, a gendered approach to literature frequently appears in the reception of modern Ottoman literature, which began in the mid-nineteenth century. For Namık Kemal, who is considered the founder of modern Ottoman literature, literature should have a 'male voice' (Yetiş 1996). Authors like

Halid Ziya and Tevfik Fikret, who turned inward and depicted their inner worlds at the end of this century, were seen by the conservative literary figures of the period as writing with a feminine sensitivity (Ercilasun 2018; Gökçek 2014). The modern Ottoman-Turkish literature, often in contact with translations from French, was frequently likened to a 'monster', and its gender was a recurring question (Gökçek 2014; Özçelebi 2003). Therefore, the genders of domestic and foreign literatures and their union have been an ongoing characterisation alongside the modernisation of Ottoman literature, continuing into the Republican period. It is also pertinent to recall that between 1914 and 1928, a considerable number of obscene literary works were published in Ottoman-Turkish literature (Sarıtaş 2020; Toprak 2017). During this roughly decade-long period, sexuality became a significant subject of literature, creating a queer literary environment where literary genres intertwined. Consequently, the interest of both contemporary medicine and literature in sexuality, as well as the positioning of Ottoman-Turkish literature within the frameworks of sexuality and gender in its relationship with modernity, is deeply embedded in the memory of this literature.

Peyami Safa's *Havva'nın Üvey Kızları* was published at the end of this period, in 1928, and initially depicts a tolerance towards female homosexuality, described as a third way beyond traditional male and female roles. Keeping in mind Puar's proposal to focus on the state's debate over the acceptability of homosexual bodies as an analysis of modernity, I argue that several events and the discussions surrounding them, occurring just before the novel began serialisation, laid the groundwork for the tolerance depicted in the work. Chief among these were the establishment of the Turkish Women's Union in 1924 and the increasing political demands of women, the widespread suicides (Maksudyan 2009; Toprak 2011) among Muslim women in 1927, and the debates on 'pansexualism[1]' concerning individuals attracted to both men and women.

The Turkish Women's Union, officially established in 1924, was an organisation that demanded the emergence of women in the new Republic not only as mothers who establish families and raise children but also as political figures, aiming to extend gender equality beyond the family sphere (Sancar 2004; Zihnioğlu 2003). The demands made by this organisation regarding women were frequently criticised and even ridiculed by the male intellectuals of the period. It is evident that the title of Peyami Safa's novel references Yunus Nadi's description of the organisation's women as 'Eve's daughters', with Safa opting for 'Eve's stepdaughters'. In Yunus Nadi's designation of 'Eve's daughters', there is a prevailing discourse that the 'gentle sex', or women, should not interfere in men's affairs, implying their alleged biological and intellectual inferiority compared to men (Sancar 2004, 109). By adding 'step' to 'Eve's daughters', Safa introduces another dimension to the notion of women straying from their natural state. While Yunus Nadi compares the nature of women to that of men, Safa adds that women can only fully realise their femininity by experiencing their sexuality with men. This perspective aligns with the contemporary debates on 'womanhood' of those times. Writers like Peyami Safa opposed the idea that the women of the early Republic could

[1]Naci Fikret penned numerous essays on this: 'Din ve Cinsiyet', 'Psikanaliz ve Panseksüalizm', 'İctimai Hayatta Cinsiyetin Rolü,' *see.* Coşkun Taştan, 'Türkiye'de Psikanaliz Hakkında En Eski Metinleri-', İstanbul, 2011. In his 'Yorgun Sinirler ve Marazi Aşklar', Fahrettin Kerim Gökay argues that female homosexuality is more frequent in Turkish society compared to other societies (Sarıtaş 2020, 330), and Mazhar Osman adds female homosexuality to the new edition of Tababet-i Ruhiye in 1926, which he had not discussed in the first edition (322).

undertake the same roles as men, contending that such equality would lead to the masculinisation of women, a view he sometimes connected to the prevalent Freudian theories of the era.

In 1925, İzeddin Şadan, one of the prominent figures in the discussions on pansexualism and a student of Freud, wrote the following:

> The most fervent Freudians are distinctly observed among philosophers, literary figures, and salon arbiters. With their long pushed-back and pomaded hair and their tightly fitted clothing, these 'pansexualist' specialists, who strut around discussing theories of love and hysteria with ladies, have no other choice but to be followers of Freud. (qtd in Taştan 2011, 89)

Şadan also mentions the popularity of Freudianism in 'women's gatherings' (qtd in Taştan 2011, 92). In the years 1925–1926, individuals labelled as 'pansexualists' appeared to occupy a dangerous position within gender classifications because they expressed sexual interest without regard to who or what the other person was. Mustafa Şekip, who translated works by both Bergson and Freud, highlights the importance of gender in Freudianism in his 1926 article titled 'Freudianism'. In his 1927 book, *İlk Gençlik Hakkında Ruhiyat ve Terbiye Tetkikleri* [*Psychological and Educational Studies on Early Youth*], İbrahim Alaaddin focuses on the concept of pansexualism within Freudian thought. (qtd in Taştan 2011, 125, 174)

During this period, both the masculinisation of the 'gentle sex' and the accompanying pansexualism brought to light the issue of women being most affected by societal changes, a phenomenon also linked to increasing suicide rates. This led to the discussion of assigning national duties and ideals to women. Max Bonnafous, who studied suicides in Turkish society between 1916 and 1926, published his findings in Turkish and French journals. His research revealed that young Muslim women had the highest suicide rates. 'The freedom brought by the Republic imposed new responsibilities on women, leading to heightened sensitivities due to their failures' (qtd in Maksudyan 2009, 60–66). Youth were caught between secularism and the old religious system, exacerbating their sensitivities. Turkish nationalism struggled to fill this gap effectively, as it could not replace religion, leaving a void in spirituality. Men and women did not feel adequately at ease regarding love and marriage, necessitating the provision of national ideals for them to hold onto (60–66).

In a manner parallel to Yunus Nadi's criticism of the Turkish Women's Union's attempts to enter politics as 'disparaging women and womanhood', *Havva'nın Üvey Kızları* aims to transform 'Eve's stepdaughters' back into 'Eve's daughters'. This transformation is portrayed as rescuing them from both pansexualism and misguided alliances among women, such as those seen in the Turkish Women's Union, as well as from their increased sensitivity leading to suicides. Indeed, in the novel, the four women describe their homosexuality as a 'kutsal ittifak' (sacred alliance) (Bedi 1928, 56). Rıfkı turns this 'sacred alliance' into a 'cursed alliance'. Through Rıfkı's tolerance, the bonds between true womanhood, sisterhood, family, and motherhood are re-established among the women. This tolerance becomes a form of pressure, which ultimately leads to the inclusion of those who return to being true women into the nation, thereby delivering a societal message of homonationalism: homosexual bodies can be tolerated, but only if they recognise homosexuality as a disease through this tolerance and decide to become women again. The path to true womanhood is to form a family and

bear children, not to realise one's nature and commit suicide. However, first, these homosexual women need to be identified and brought out of the 'closet'.

Sedgwick's concept of the 'closet', defined as a 'metaphorical secret space where non-heterosexual individuals suppress their homosexual desires or live their desires in secrecy, fearing persecution if such desire or sexual activity is exposed' (1990, 3), explores the conditions under which this space forms and its relationship with modernity and modes of thought. This analysis delves into the foundations of the hetero-homo distinction. Sedgwick highlights the contradictions between bringing homosexuality out of the closet and keeping it hidden. She suggests that recognising these contradictions between exposure and secrecy will uncover other unnoticed relationships and secrets (1990). To uncover these secrets, Sedgwick proposes two types of readings for queer literary texts: paranoid reading and reparative reading. In this context, I relate Rıfkı's approach to uncovering the secret among the women to a paranoid reading and identify him as a paranoid reader.

Reversing the inversion

In Ottoman-Turkish literature, texts addressing female homosexuality increased at the turn of the twentieth century. While earlier works depicted female homosexuality and love as perversions, later works such as Recaizade Ekrem's *Saime*, Ahmet Rasim's *Hamamcı Ülfet*, and Şahabeddin Süleyman's *Çıkmaz Sokak* emphasized the beauty and purity of women in their portrayals of love and sexuality between women (Sarıtaş 2020, 332–336; Schick 2000). Similarly, in *Havva'nın Üvey Kızları*, the women, with the exception of Neriman, are noted for their beauty. These works continue to depict relationships between women as secrets, emphasising the clandestine nature of these connections, a theme that persists in *Havva'nın Üvey Kızları*.

The novel progresses as Rıfkı, after encountering a woman on the street and running after her to introduce himself, marries her. This woman, named Piraye, along with her three friends, are revealed to be lesbians. In this relationship, Şükran and Semahat form one couple, while Neriman and Piraye form the other. Initially unaware of these relationships, Rıfkı becomes angry upon discovering the relationship between Neriman and his wife Piraye. However, he subsequently shows them tolerance and begins to contemplate the reasons behind lesbianism among women. After learning about his wife and her friends' lesbianism, Rıfkı starts reading about homosexuality. He reads, comments on, and quotes from Freud's *Three Essays on the Theory of Sexuality* in front of us, the readers.

Although Freud's work is mentioned in the novel, it is not referred to directly by name. Instead, it is described as the work of an Austrian doctor:

> An Austrian doctor has conducted studies on this subject. Read them. He mentioned the title of a book. I obtained this blue-covered French book. One night, I read and finished the entire volume until morning. This book, titled *Three Essays on the Theory of Sexuality*, captivated me, taught me so much, and made me ponder deeply. (Bedi 1928, 59)

In the novel, Rıfkı reads this book in front of the readers, while simultaneously contemplating Piraye's situation in depth. He aligns his thoughts with Freud's writings, ultimately equating her 'inversion', or homosexuality, with the potential for rehabilitation:

> The doctor states in his work that this issue has traditionally been explained as an 'inborn degeneration', but he argues that this notion is incorrect. If it were inborn, he says, 'accidental inverts' would not exist. Furthermore, this doctor does not accept that inversion is a degeneration or decline, because such individuals exhibit no abnormalities in their physical structures or anatomical conditions, nor do they lack intelligence. In fact, many renowned and highly esteemed individuals are among them, he says. So, if this condition, this 'inversion', is not an ailment, what is it? The author states that there is a popular misconception: people believe that an individual is either male or female. Science has begun to disprove this belief. Scientifically, it is proven that some individuals possess both male and female reproductive organs. Moreover, it is scientifically established that, without exception, every individual carries a trace of the opposite sex; that is, in males, there is a small and primitive remnant of female reproductive organs, which either perform a different function or are inactive. (Bedi 1928, 59–60)

Rıfkı concludes that if Piraye is one of these 'accidental inverts', she can be cured and decides to observe and study her like a scientist. Through these actions, Rıfkı transforms into a reader engaging in paranoid reading, one of the types of readings Sedgwick proposes for queer literary criticism.

Sedgwick develops the concept of paranoid reading by critiquing Freud's notion of paranoia. In his work *The Schreber Case* (1911), Freud analyzes homosexual desire as a symptom of paranoia. In contrast, Sedgwick adopts Melanie Klein's approach to paranoia. Unlike Freud, Klein defines paranoia not as a symptom but as a position, emphasising the potential for paranoia to transition from a state of suspicion and anxiety to a reparative process through a depressive attitude in intermediary situations (Sedgwick 1990, 25). Rıfkı, by reinforcing his reading experience with Freud, validates the Freudian paranoia critiqued by Sedgwick. This initial tolerance shown towards women, supported by homonationalism, goes a step further as he perceives the homosexual desire among women as an illness and attempts to cure it, thereby upholding and even glorifying the masculine position of the nation-state. In doing so, Rıfkı first identifies these 'unnatural habits' as if diagnosing a disease, and then transforms into a doctor treating the named symptom. This is a common scenario in Safa's works.

In 1922, under the pseudonym Safiye Peyman, Peyami Safa published the novel *Sözde Kızlar*, where he emphasises the immorality of modernising women by prefixing the word 'girls' with 'so-called'. In *Sözde Kızlar*, with the introduction of Western values into society, girls who leave the traditional family environment for tea parties and ballroom dances interact with men, seeking modernity through entertainment and illegitimate relationships outside of traditional values. Thus, Safa labels them as 'so-called girls'. Six years later, he publishes another work under a pseudonym, this time as Server Bedi, titled *Havva'nın Üvey Kızları*. In this work, instead of girls corrupted by Western values and illegitimate relationships with men, women who engage in sexual relationships with their own gender take their place.

In *Sözde Kızlar*, Safa attributes the corruption of women to Western values, which he argues alienate them from family-oriented and maternal roles. In *Havva'nın Üvey Kızları*, he extends his critique beyond the family and motherhood, questioning the friendships and solidarity among women. This shift can be partly explained by the establishment of the Turkish Women's Union in 1925 and the growing political demands of women during this period. As a result, while *Sözde Kızlar* features a female protagonist who

contracts syphilis due to relationships with men, *Havva'nın Üvey Kızları* portrays women afflicted by psychological and physical ailments arising from their same-sex relationships. In Safa's literary framework, unrestrained desires often manifest as a form of illness (Ayvazoğlu 2008).

From the mid-nineteenth century onward, literary portrayals of homosexual protagonists became increasingly rare, and female homosexuality was similarly labelled as 'morbid' (Sarıtaş 2020, 330) – pathological and diseased – in contemporary medical literature (Andrews and Kalpaklı 2005; Arvas 2014; Sarıtaş 2020; Schick 2000; Ze'evi 2005). In *Havva'nın Üvey Kızları*, after Rıfkı learns of the women's homosexuality, he engages them in discussions, asserting that their sexuality is not 'womanly'. As a result, the women begin to internalise the idea that their same-sex desires are a disease. This notion is further symbolised through literal illness in the novel. It is no coincidence that first Piraye and then Neriman fall ill. Despite medical intervention, the doctors fail to diagnose their illnesses; Piraye eventually recovers, but Neriman dies.

As the narrative progresses, Rıfkı's discovery of his wife Piraye's and her friends' homosexuality triggers a series of events centred around illness. Initially, Rıfkı problematises this situation by attributing it to young girls studying with their same-sex peers in boarding schools. As Piraye and Neriman fall ill, and their secret is revealed, Rıfkı transforms into a paranoid reader, as I have previously demonstrated. Readers who followed the novel in its serialised form would undergo a similar process, witnessing Rıfkı's journey to uncover the secret. Thus, the readers of the serialised novel also witness Rıfkı's efforts to cure the homosexual women under his tolerance. First, the secret of homosexuality among the women is exposed. Then, the women themselves, through their own admissions, express that they cannot be considered true women in their current state. Rıfkı, showing compassion even towards Neriman, his wife's lover, pities her for being a homosexual woman rather than a true woman. Ultimately, by impregnating his wife Piraye and ensuring she gives birth to a son, Rıfkı invests in the heteronormative future of the nation.

After Rıfkı uncovers the secret about Şükriye and Semahat, they begin to perceive their long-standing relationship as a 'disease' that must be 'cured'. This shift in perception causes them to become 'victims' in Rıfkı's eyes. He attributes their predicament to the boarding school they attended, believing the environment fostered such tendencies. These young women, isolated from anyone other than their same-sex peers during their education, allegedly developed this 'habit' at school. Semahat reveals their secret to Rıfkı with the following explanation:

> I assure you that we all hated men. Even I, who had a slight weakness for men, deeply felt this hatred. We constantly talked about the ugliness of men among ourselves. 'Their heads are large, their flesh is hard, their bones are big, their hair is abundant, their voices are deep, their souls are coarse', we would say. None of us paid any attention to the young men in our families, our neighbors' children, or those closest to us. And as long as we lived without men, we did not feel any deprivation. Our loves, our beautiful eyes, and our beautiful bodies were sufficient for us. Gradually, we learned that this feeling was not exclusive to boarding schools; many married or widowed women were like us. Especially in Istanbul, we discovered that the city was full of women like us. These women, who used to recognize each other by wearing scarves around their necks and other special signs, were not diminishing in number but were actually increasing. (Bedi 1928, 57)

The boarding school, composed solely of young girls, transformed into a queer space. After some time, they also became acquainted with other queer spaces outside the school:

> We met many new people and welcomed them into our gatherings. However, we never broke our sacred alliance and never made each other jealous. We even found women from prominent families in Şişli and Kadıköy, well-known names. They invited us to their luxurious apartments equipped with electricity, hot baths, and every comfort. (Bedi 1928, 87–88)

This situation, which underscores the alleged risks associated with young people attending same-sex schools, parallels the doctor-nurse dynamic seen when Rıfkı and Neriman care for Piraye during her illness. When Piraye falls ill, Neriman tends to her like a nurse. Notably, in Turkish, the word *hemşire* means both 'nurse' and 'sister'. During Piraye's illness, Rıfkı begins to view Neriman as a sister. However, throughout the novel, Neriman and Piraye themselves do not perceive each other as sisters until Neriman's death. This raises critical questions: Why is Neriman killed off by illness at the end of the novel rather than when her homosexuality is first revealed? Why does she become a part of Piraye's recovery process as the subject of homosexual desire? These choices reflect a paranoid reading of homosexuality, followed by a homonationalist stance that offers conditional tolerance while simultaneously imposing pressure. Through this lens, Neriman and others like her are compelled to internalise their marginalisation, framing themselves as 'ill' and thereby relegating their desires to the periphery. This dynamic brings to mind Eve Sedgwick's observation that those who come out of the closet are not always limited to the individuals expected to emerge; instead, coming out can lead to surprising and unintended revelations (1991).

While supporting Piraye during her illness, Rıfkı occasionally feels sympathy and pity for Neriman:

> I pitied Neriman. She seemed as natural to me as a man speaking about his wife. Love, which transcends everything, manages all people, builds invisible bridges between hearts, and breathes life into life itself, was beautifying this girl's unnatural passion. I felt no sense of competition or jealousy towards her. She was like a sister to me. I caressed her hand with a protective touch. (Bedi 1928, 67)

Sedgwick posits that paranoid reading, as an interpretive stance, can evolve into reparative reading, with love being a pivotal element in facilitating this transformation (Hanson 2011, 101–119; Wiegmann 2014, 4–25; Stockton 2023, 1–21, Sifaki et al. 2022, 29–66). When Rıfkı ceases to see Neriman as an 'unnatural creature' and briefly regards her as a lover, he steps momentarily out of paranoia and into a reparative framework. This fleeting moment illustrates how the energy of queerness can transcend paranoia and contribute to the possibility of reparative reading. However, this queer energy, inadvertently revealed by Rıfkı and beyond both his and the author's conscious intentions, also seals Neriman's fate: death. Once Neriman's queer existence is exposed, it holds the potential to permeate the narrative, transforming tolerance into love and shifting away from the paranoia that frames tolerance as oppressive. This shift disrupts homonationalism, a stance that cloaks its pressure in the guise of acceptance. Indeed, the emergence of this energy compels Rıfkı to question the definitive success of his efforts to rehabilitate the four homosexual women and re-educate them as 'true women'. However, this doubt is resolved only through narrative violence: one woman becomes pregnant, and the

other dies. Crucially, neither woman abandons her homosexual desires voluntarily. Through its male protagonist, the narrative implies that the first woman, by becoming pregnant, is biologically redefined as a 'true woman' despite her intentions, while the second dies because she refuses to renounce her 'unnatural' desires.

In fact, throughout her marriage to Rıfkı, Piraye neither seems to have truly found the 'right path', nor she wishes to separate from Neriman. Furthermore, the relationship between Neriman and Piraye is presented as a threat. Neriman's queerness is represented not only through the feelings directed toward her but also through her physical body. At times, she is described as more masculine than feminine in Rıfkı's eyes:

> I scrutinized Neriman. She is the exact opposite of Piraye: her body is upright, her flesh as firm as her bones, her eyebrows furrowed. There is a certain grandeur, a self-control, even a masculinity in her demeanor. Her voice is cracked and deep when she speaks. Her gestures are decisive. She commands her friends with her deep voice like an officer. (Bedi 1928, 10)

Described as 'this soulless creature', Neriman is a perpetual source of unease in the novel. Rıfkı often refers to her as a 'creature'. In contrast, he describes Şükriye as a 'sweet, cheerful woman' and Semahat as 'a woman whose charm and coquetry is evident at first sight, elegantly dressed, beautiful, and lively'. This distinction arises because Şükriye and Semahat are perceived as amenable to rehabilitation, whereas Neriman, deemed either incapable or unwilling to be rehabilitated, is condemned to die.

After Neriman returns to take care of Piraye during her illness, Rıfkı, Neriman, and Piraye begin living together. One day, when Rıfkı returns home unexpectedly, he spies on them through the keyhole of the room they are in and becomes very angry at what he sees. What Rıfkı witnesses is not disclosed to us readers, but the information that one of them was leaning towards the other, along with the male character's anger, provides a clue as to what might have occurred. Following this incident, Neriman falls ill. Meanwhile, Piraye has already become pregnant by Rıfkı.

When Piraye learns she is pregnant, she particularly desires a male child. Rıfkı interprets this as 'valuing masculinity and men' (Bedi 1928, 111). With her pregnancy, Piraye will 'escape her ominous habit' and, as 'her child nurses from her, she will succeed in nursing from Eve herself and become more feminine' (110). In this way, the issue of 'step-hood' will be resolved, and Piraye will regain her 'true' self.

At the end of the novel, the four homosexual women come together, declare themselves sisters, and promise Neriman that they will overcome their 'ways'. As Neriman is dying, she does not refrain from giving advice to her former lovers, now her new sisters:

> Semahat … Piraye … Şükriye … My sisters … Bid me farewell. You will all live married lives. Marry … Like women … Like true women (Bedi 1928, 77). I … Could never marry. I … You know … Am ugly. I … Have done you all … I … Unintentionally … Harm. (Bedi 1928, 120)

As a result of Rıfkı's paranoid reading, these women, exposed through paranoia, must be reformed and rescued from 'masculinisation'. It is not just Neriman who has become masculinised. Semahat, Şükriye, Piraye, and Neriman have all become the unacceptable, 'bad' women of the Republic because they have received a good education, acquired professions, and turned towards homosexual desire, contrary to the heteronormative desire

imposed on them. Indeed, in many of Peyami Safa's books, women who distance themselves from motherhood and become obsessed with adornment and sensuality are portrayed negatively, often meeting their end in death. Fatmagül Berktay, in her writing on Peyami Safa, discusses the shared perspective of Freud and Safa on women as a 'mystery', noting Freud's description of women as an enigma. She states:

> A woman who reasons and can comment on herself ceases to be a mystery and becomes a 'solver of mysteries', that is, a subject. In the intellectual worlds of both Freud and Peyami Safa, this means that the woman ceases to be a woman and becomes masculinized. (1999, 267)

In the novel, it is a man who defines the homosexual relationship among the four women, describing Neriman as 'masculine' and labelling them as 'Eve's stepdaughters'. This categorisation is reinforced by the women's own declaration: 'We cannot even be called women'. Rıfkı's act of naming parallels his role as the painter of Piraye's portrait.

Rıfkı is particularly eager to paint Piraye's portrait and claims to be an artist who captures not only the visible but also the essence of his subjects. What draws him to Piraye is not her conventional beauty – he explicitly states that she is not particularly beautiful but deeply captivating. This implies that the portrait he creates will embody Piraye as perceived through his lens. Later in the narrative, when Piraye falls ill and begins to see her love for Neriman as a 'disease', she gazes at her portrait, which hangs in her room. Through Rıfkı's depiction of her, she views herself as he does and starts to transform inwardly into the Piraye rendered in his painting.

The portrait's role in the novel evokes Oscar Wilde's *The Picture of Dorian Gray*, particularly its exploration of secrets embedded within portraits. By way of painting Piraye's 'soul', Rıfkı exposes her hidden desires and, in doing so, reinforces the necessity of suppressing them. While Wilde's novel is central to queer literature, it is only subtly alluded to in *Havva'nın Üvey Kızları*. Similar to Safa's fleeting, indirect reference to Freud – who is merely called 'the Austrian doctor' – the intertextual link to Wilde remains unspoken.

In Safa's novel, Piraye eventually comes to see her queer desires as aberrations, encouraged by Rıfkı's portrayal of her in the painting. She resolves to renounce her homosexuality and strive to become a 'genuine' woman. The transformation of Wilde's subversive exploration of queer desire into the heteronormative framework of *Havva'nın Üvey Kızları* is stark. In *The Picture of Dorian Gray*, the painter's unspoken yearning for the young man he immortalises is transformed, in Safa's work, into a man's desire to define and 'domesticate' a woman. Similarly, when Rıfkı attempts to scientifically analyse his wife's homosexuality, the text makes implicit reference to Freud's *Three Essays on the Theory of Sexuality* without ever naming the work outright.

Safa's implicit reference to Wilde's work does not merely transpose the relationship to a heterosexual level between a man and a woman but also emphasises the roles of femininity and masculinity. By impregnating the woman whose portrait he painted, he transforms her into 'Eve's true woman', thereby reversing the inversion.

Conclusion

In *Havva'nın Üvey Kızları*, the initial tolerance shown by the novel's male protagonist toward the lesbian characters creates a mechanism of pressure that ultimately leads

these women to internalise a belief that they are not 'truly' women. This perception compels them to view themselves as ill, in need of treatment and reform. Such a narrative dynamic exemplifies homonationalism by promoting a policy of marginalisation and reform directed at homosexuals, and contributes to the gendered nation-building process of the early Republic. The sanctity of the family is paramount here, which underscores the imperative that women uphold their roles as mothers. Therefore, women who deviate from motherhood must be identified. Sedgwick's paranoid reading is relevant here: secrets must be unearthed, and homosexuality must be brought 'out of the closet'. However, not only homosexuality but also other unsettling revelations emerge from this closet. Among these are not not only the lesbian identities of the four women but also the potential for queerness to transform paranoia into a reparative process, as well as the homophobia that intensifies this paranoia, since the novel's tolerance quickly shifts toward a disclosure of reform. Indeed, Rıfkı's homonationalism, initially expressed as tolerance, quickly devolves into homophobia as he seeks to 'tame' these women.

This situation manifests not only in the male protagonist's attempt to subdue female homosexuality through homonationalism – by impregnating a woman to ensure she bears a male child, thereby reinstating her as a 'true' woman – but also in the implicit fear that the nation's men could themselves be queer. This fear, deeply intertwined with the rhetoric of masculinity, stems from homophobia being brought out into the open. If this fear did not exist, Rıfkı's efforts to 'cure' Piraye's 'illness' – both her homosexuality and her physical fever in the novel – might have sufficed. However, these measures alone are not enough; he ensures her pregnancy with a male child and orchestrates extensive praise for masculinity.

In concluding this article, I aim to shift focus from the paranoid to the reparative, engaging with this queer text not as a paranoid reader like Rıfkı, but as a reparative one. By examining Rıfkı – who, albeit briefly, shifts from a paranoid to a reparative stance when he views Neriman not as an unnatural figure but as a loving subject during her shared illness with Piraye – the work of an author often celebrated as a bastion of nationalism in Turkish literature reveals, even if momentarily, the possibilities of the queer. This fleeting moment unveils a potential counter-narrative to the intended discourse of reformability, despite the author's intentions. It underscores the revolutionary potential of queerness as a persistent and subversive presence. Furthermore, the male protagonist's paranoid reading urges readers toward an alternative, reparative reading, positioning us outside and beyond his limited perspective.

Acknowledgements

I would like to thank Serdar Soydan, with whom I met from time to time during the writing of this article to discuss the novel *Havva'nın Üvey Kızları* (Eve's Stepdaughters), and the reviewers and İpek Şahinler for their valuable critics.

Disclosure statement

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the author(s).

Notes on contributor

Seval Şahin is a faculty member at Mimar Sinan Fine Arts University, Department of Turkish Language and Literature. She is interested in the sociology of literary forms, everyday life in literature and detective fiction. Between 2011 and 2014, she conducted a research project supported by TUBITAK on 'the history of detective fiction published in Turkey in 1884–1928'. Her published books: Kültürel Sermaye, Kibar Hırsız ve Şehir (Bağlam Yayınları, 2011), Modernizmin Oyunu-Oyunun Modernizmi, Tanpınar'da Oyun (Kapı Yayınları, 2013), Cinai Meseleler- Osmanlı-Türk Polisiye Edebiyatinde Biçim ve İdeoloji (1884–1928) (İletişim Yayınları, 2017) and Talih, Tesadüf ve İrade -Ahmet Hamdi Tanpınar'ın Romancılığı Üzerine Düşünceler- (İletişim Publications, 2019). She prepared edited books on writers such as Peyami Safa, Ahmet Hamdi Tanpınar, Sevgi Soysal, Yakup Kadri Karaosmanoğlu, Bilge Karasu, Nezihe Meriç, Mehmet Rauf. She was part of the preparation team of Turkey's first Women's Writing Festival in 2019. Since April 2015, she has been preparing and presenting the programme 'Günün ve Güncelin Edebiyatı', which has been broadcast every Thursday at 14:00 on Apaçık Radyo.

ORCID

Seval Şahin http://orcid.org/0000-0003-1548-6763

References

Andrews, Walter, and Mehmet Kalpaklı. 2005. *The Age of Beloved: Love and the Beloved in Early-Modern Ottoman and European Culture and Society*. Durham and London: Duke University Press.

Arvas, Abdülhamit. 2014. *The Cambridge History of Gay and Lesbian Literature*. Edited by E.L. McCallum and Mikko Tuhkanen, 145–163. New York: Cambridge University Press.

Ayda, Adile. 1998. *Bir Demet Edebiyat*. İstanbul: Türkiye İş Bankası Yayınları.

Ayvazoğlu, Beşir. 2008. *Peyami: Hayatı, Sanatı, Felsefesi, Dramı*. İstanbul: Kapı Yayınları.

Berktay, Fatmagül. 1999. "Yeni Kimlik Arayışı, Eski Cinsel Dualizm: Peyami Safa'nın Romanlarında Toplumsal Cinsiyet." In *Bilanço 1923-1998, Tarih Vakfı, Uluslar arası Kongre Kitabı*. İstanbul: Tarih Vakfı Yurt Yayınları.

Ercilasun, Bilge. 2018. *Servet-i Fünun'da Edebi Tenkit*. Ankara: Akçağ Yayınları.

Gökçek, Fazıl. 2014. *Bir Tartışmanın Hikâyesi: Dekadanlar*. İstanbul: Dergâh Yayınları.

Gürbilek, Nurdan. 2012. *Kör Ayna, Kayıp Şark*. İstanbul: Metis Yayınları.

Hanson, Ellis. 2011. "The Future's Eve: Reparative Reading after Sedgwick." *South Atlantic Quarterly* 110 (1): 101–119. https://doi.org/10.1215/00382876-2010-025

Haralson, Eric. 2009. *Henry James and Queer Modernity*. New York: Cambridge University Press.

Maksudyan, Nazan. 2009. "Erken Cumhuriyet Döneminde Kadın İntiharları: Islah, İnkâr, İskat." *Toplumsal Tarih* 188:60–66.

Moran, Berna. 2044. *Türk Romanına Eleştirel Bir Bakış -2*. İstanbul: İletişim Yayınları.

Özçelebi, Betül. 2003. *Cumhuriyet Döneminde Edebi Eleştiri 1923-1938*. Ankara: Kültür Bakanlığı Yayınları.

Puar, Jasbir K. 2007. *Terrorist Assemblages: Homonationalism in Queer Times*. Durham, DC: Duke University Press.

Puar, Jasbir. 2013. "Rethinking Homonationalism." *International Journal of Middle East Studies* 45 (2): 336–339. https://doi.org/10.1017/S002074381300007X

Safa, Peyami. 2022. *Kadın, Aşk, Aile*. İstanbul: Ötüken Neşriyat.

Şahin, Seval. 2011. *Kültürel Sermaye, Kibar Hırsız ve Şehir*. İstanbul: Bağlam Yayınları.

Sancar, Serpil. 2004. *Türk Modernleşmesinin Cinsiyeti*. İstanbul: İletişim Yayınları.

Sarıtaş, Ezgi. 2020. *Cinsel Normalliğin Kuruluşu: Osmanlı'dan Cumhuriyet'e Heteronormatiflik ve İstikrarsızlıkları*. İstanbul: Metis Yayınları.

Schick, Irwin Cemil. 2000. *Batının Cinsel Kıyısı*. İstanbul: Tarih Vakfı Yurt Yayınları.
Sedgwick, Eve Kosofsky. 1990. *Epistemology of the Closet*. Berkeley: University of California Press.
Sedgwick, Eve Kosofsky. "Paranoid Reading and Reparative Reading; Or, You're so Paranoid, you Probably Think this Introduction is About You." In *Novel Gazing: Queer Readings in Fiction*, edited by Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick, 1–37. Durham, NC: Duke University Press.
Server Bedi (Peyami Safa). *Havva'nın Üvey Kızları*, *Son Saat*, 12 Şubat 1928– 7 Mayıs 1928.
Sifaki, Angelik, C. L. Quina, and Katarina Lončarević. 2022. *Homonationalism, Femonationalism and Ablenationalism Critical Pedagogies Contextualised*. New York: Routledge.
Soydan, Serdar. 2019. "Peyami Safa'nın Üvey Kızları." *K24*, September 19. https://t24.com.tr/k24/yazi/peyami-safa-nin-uvey-kizlari,2395.
Stockton, Will. 2023. *An Introduction to Queer Literary Studies: Reading Queerly*. New York: Routledge.
Taştan, Coşkun. 2011. *Türkiye'de Psikanaliz Hakkında En Eski Metinler-I*. İstanbul: Bağlam Yayınları.
Toprak, Zafer. 2011. "Sosyologların ve Psikiyatrislerin Farklı Yorumları: Erken Cumhuriyet Dönemi Genç Kız-Kadın İntiharları." *Toplumsal Tarih* 212:40–48.
Toprak, Zafer. 2017. "Türkiye'de Müstehcen Avam Edebiyatı (1908–1928)." *Toplumsal Tarih* 285:50–63.
Üyepazarcı, Erol. 2008. *Korkmayınız Mister Sherlock Holmes*. İstanbul: Oğlak Yayınları.
Wiegmann, Robyn. 2014. "The Times We're in: Queer Feminist Criticism and the Reparative 'Turn'." *Feminist Theory* 15 (1): 4–25. https://doi.org/10.1177/1464700113513081a
Winer, Canton, and Catherine Bolzendahl. 2021. "Conceptualizing Homonationalism: (Re)Formulation, Application, and Debates of Expansion." *Sociology Compass* 15 (5): 1–11.
Yetiş, Kazım. 1996. *Namık Kemal'in Görüş ve Yazıları*. İstanbul: Alfa Yayınları.
Ze'evi, Dror. 2005. "Hiding Sexsuality: The Disapperance of Sexual Discourse in the Late Ottoman Middle East." *Social Analysis* 49 (2): 34–53.
Zihnioğlu, Yaprak. 2003. *Kadınsız İnkılap*. İstanbul: Metis Yayınları.